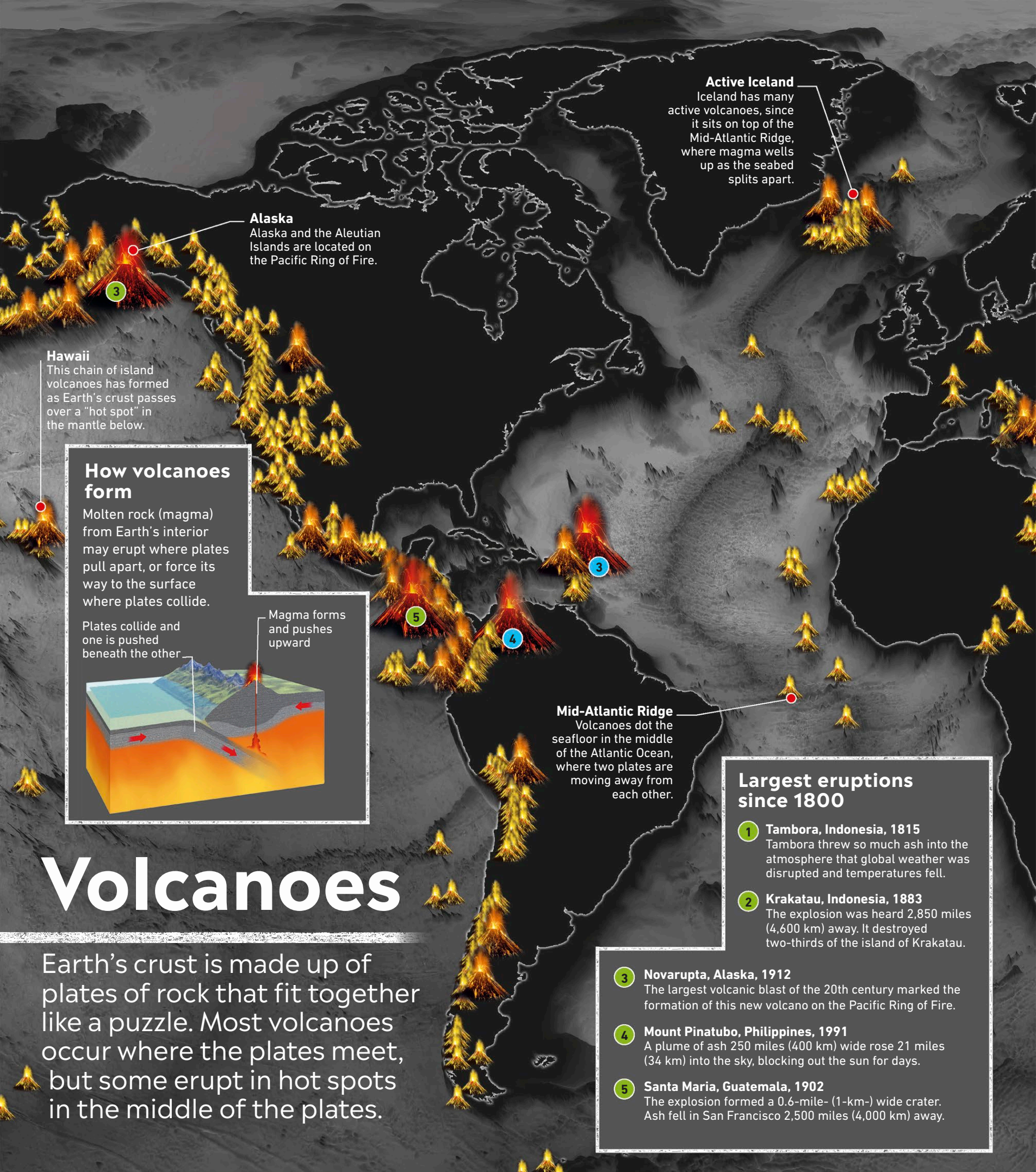




Active Iceland

Iceland has many active volcanoes, since it sits on top of the Mid-Atlantic Ridge, where magma wells up as the seabed splits apart.

Alaska

Alaska and the Aleutian Islands are located on the Pacific Ring of Fire.

Hawaii

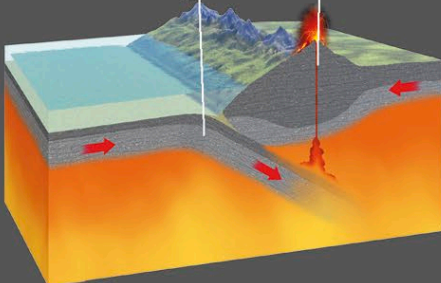
This chain of island volcanoes has formed as Earth's crust passes over a "hot spot" in the mantle below.

How volcanoes form

Molten rock (magma) from Earth's interior may erupt where plates pull apart, or force its way to the surface where plates collide.

Plates collide and one is pushed beneath the other

Magma forms and pushes upward



Mid-Atlantic Ridge

Volcanoes dot the seafloor in the middle of the Atlantic Ocean, where two plates are moving away from each other.

Largest eruptions since 1800

- 1 Tambora, Indonesia, 1815**
Tambora threw so much ash into the atmosphere that global weather was disrupted and temperatures fell.
- 2 Krakatau, Indonesia, 1883**
The explosion was heard 2,850 miles (4,600 km) away. It destroyed two-thirds of the island of Krakatau.
- 3 Novarupta, Alaska, 1912**
The largest volcanic blast of the 20th century marked the formation of this new volcano on the Pacific Ring of Fire.
- 4 Mount Pinatubo, Philippines, 1991**
A plume of ash 250 miles (400 km) wide rose 21 miles (34 km) into the sky, blocking out the sun for days.
- 5 Santa Maria, Guatemala, 1902**
The explosion formed a 0.6-mile- (1-km-) wide crater. Ash fell in San Francisco 2,500 miles (4,000 km) away.

Volcanoes

Earth's crust is made up of plates of rock that fit together like a puzzle. Most volcanoes occur where the plates meet, but some erupt in hot spots in the middle of the plates.